

THE OBSERVER

DAILY

SENSEMAKER

Friday 28 August 2026

Dear Ryan,

Welcome to today's Sensemaker.

Long stories short

- The number of people claiming asylum in the UK fell by more than 20% (more below).
- Uefa prepared to make a criminal complaint against Fifa's Gianni Infantino.
- Thieves stole bronze age treasures from a Spanish museum.

Himalayan catastrophe

by Jeevan Vasagar



At least 469 people have died and hundreds are missing in Nepal as the Asian country deals with the fallout from a flash flood on its border with Tibet.

So what? Worse could be to come. The formation of a lake in the vicinity of the disaster has raised fears that a second flood may be imminent. Unanswered questions include

- exactly how many people are beneath the water and mud;
- what more could have been done to better predict the flooding; and
- to what extent it was caused, or made likelier, by the march of climate change.

State of play. Hundreds of people, mainly foreign nationals, remain missing as the recovery efforts from Wednesday's flash flood enter a third day. Different Nepali bodies have provided differing figures but the death toll is expected to keep rising.

What happened? First it was believed that an earthquake caused a landslide, which caused a flood. But analysis now suggests a vast chunk of ice from a glacier snapped away along with its underlying bedrock and plummeted 1300m into the valley below it. The impact

when it hit the ground registered a magnitude of 5.2 on the Richter scale.

And then? Swollen by water from other decaying glaciers, the pulverised chunk swept downstream in a destructive torrent on Wednesday morning.

Then? The immense volume of water, combined with rock and other debris, had a devastating impact as it funnelled along the Bhotekoshi river. Successive waves of water ripped through bridges and demolished buildings.

View from the ground. Anish Raj Shrestha, communications manager for ActionAid Nepal, said that the flood “came at such a ferocious speed that it damaged anything it touched... People were swept away and found unconscious in the mud.”

What now? Shrestha said infrastructure damage and the risk of further flooding have combined to create major obstacles to delivering aid.

View across the border. On the Chinese side, at least three people are dead and more than 500 missing, according to state media. The deluge swept through Gyirong port, a border crossing between Nepal and China, where video of the disaster shows people running in an attempt to escape before being engulfed by floodwater.

Could more have been done? Perhaps. Nepali officials say there was no warning, despite the district experiencing something similar in 2025.

The reality. Other countries in the region have adapted to environmental threats. Bangladesh has sharply reduced mortality from cyclones over the past five decades, through early warning systems, cyclone shelters and coastal defences.

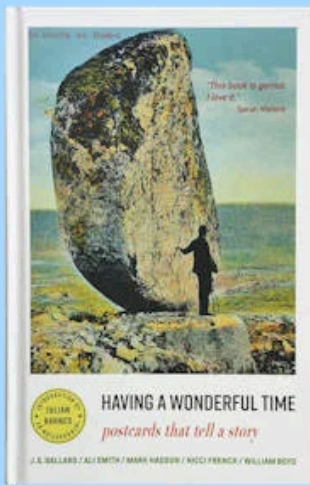
The problem. An Indian Ocean cyclone is easier to forecast and track than the crumbling of a glacier, which needs substantial investment in monitoring.

The cause. Researchers are trying to determine the extent to which the Nepal-Tibet disaster bears the fingerprints of climate change. Satellite images show snow cover on the glacier the day before, but no snow cover the day after, which researchers say might indicate a “high altitude warming event”, when the temperature spikes high in the atmosphere. That may have led to meltwater penetrating and loosening bedrock underneath.

The bigger picture is that a warming planet has made events like this more likely. Glaciers in the world’s highest mountains are melting at a quickening pace, with rates of ice loss doubling since 2000. The combination of retreating glaciers and thawing permafrost due to climate change makes mountain landscapes increasingly unstable.

Disaster repeated. What happened this week is comparable to flash floods in the Indian state of Uttarakhand in 2021. A Himalayan glacier broke and crumbled into a river, killing dozens of people and smashing through hydropower stations.

What’s more... The Himalayas and Hindu Kush have the planet’s largest ice and snow deposits outside of the poles, feeding the Ganges, Indus and Brahmaputra. Floods aside, millions of people depend on the flow of this water for their survival.



Live event

The Observer Book Club: Postcards Live!

with Julian Barnes, Mark Haddon,
Chloe Aridjis & Akshi Singh

17 September 2026 | 18:30–19:30 BST

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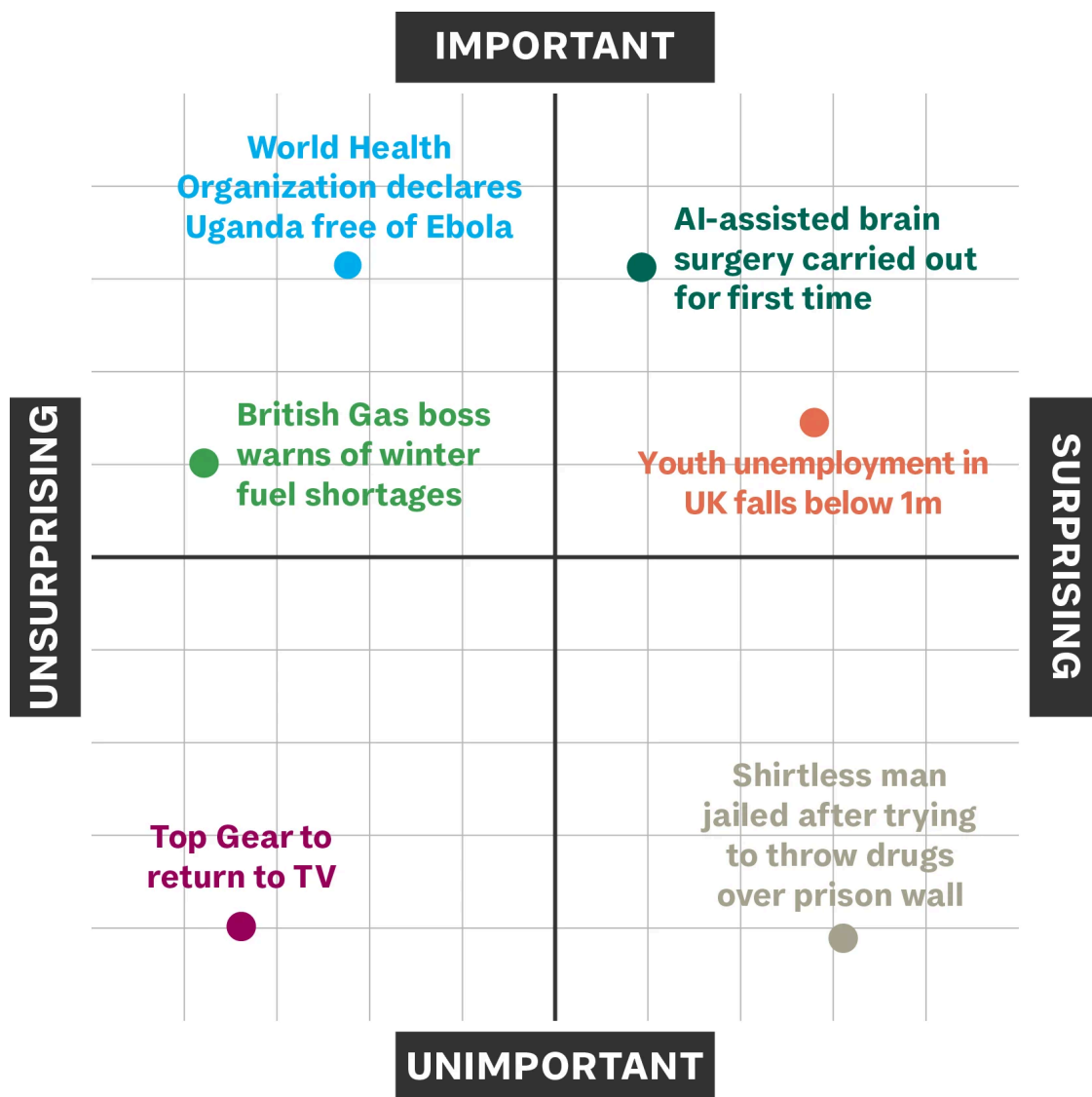
It may be a simple thing – image on one side, a few scrawled lines on the other – but a postcard always tells a story. This September, to beat the post-summer-holiday comedown, *The Observer* and Redstone Press are hosting a celebration of this small but mighty form in our London newsroom – a special event marking the publication of *Having a Wonderful Time*, an anthology of original fiction inspired by real postcards that goes beyond the weather updates to offer love letters, secrets, disasters, laughter and delight.

Our top-flight cast of authors – Chloe Aridjis (*The Shadow of the Object*), Mark Haddon (*The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time*), Akshi Singh (*In Defence of Leisure: Experiments in Living*), and Booker-winning novelist Julian Barnes – will read their stories, share their love of dog-eared holiday missives, and perhaps even try their hand, with any keen audience members, at some live postcard-writing.

Wish you were there? [Join us on 17 September](#), and you can be.

[Book your tickets here](#). Tickets are free for Observer subscribers.

The Observer News Matrix



The Nibs

Capital Economy, business and finance

Money machine

Nvidia, the world's most valuable company, has shrugged off its doubters with projected revenue growth of 70% next financial year. CEO Jensen Huang said only supply chain issues were constraining Nvidia from even higher levels of growth. Although customers are developing their own chips to reduce reliance on Nvidia, Huang explained that demand continues to soar from changes in the way AI operates, particularly systems that act independently and require heavy computing power. Nvidia, which now comprises more than 7%

of the S&P 500, [more than doubled](#) its profits last year. Its projection of future success seems designed to send a message to investors waiting for the bubble to pop. What bubble?

Technology AI, science and new things

Rockstar flex

After 12 years in development, *Grand Theft Auto VI* is drawing near. A 30-minute extended look, streamed on Netflix yesterday, reveals a few things about the most anticipated game of all time. Firstly, the graphics are incredible. Secondly, there will be no shortage of side activities for players, from kayaking to scuba diving. Thirdly, it will be possible to pet dogs. As for the main storyline of Jason and Lucia, quasi-ciphers for Bonnie and Clyde, wait and see. An extended look can only show so much and the megacut of their interactions became repetitive. Two questions arise: can a satirical game that has been in development for a decade feel current or prescient? And how much does it matter how good the game is given there have been more than 4m pre-orders before it is even released? *GTA VI* may have already saved the industry.

Poisoned chalice

New figures provide the usual pick 'n' mix for those who want to say that the UK government is or is not doing enough on migration. The number of asylum claims are down by more than a fifth, but the number of migrants applying to settle in the UK has reached a 16-year high. Shabana Mahmood, the home secretary, will hope to address the latter data point by changing the rules on who is allowed to live, work and study in Britain permanently. Under reforms due to be introduced this autumn, most foreign nationals will have to wait 10 years to be eligible for indefinite leave to remain, up from five years at present. Refugees will have to wait 20 years. One thing is certain. Whatever this does to migration numbers, the right still won't be happy.

Our planet **Climate and geopolitics**

Unroutine

The flying visit that John Ratcliffe, the CIA director, paid to Moscow this week was reportedly to tell the Kremlin not to attack Nato. That's [according](#) to the *WSJ*, which has strong security sources and previously reported on US intelligence assessments warning that Putin could launch a limited incursion against an alliance member within weeks. Donald Trump has played down Ratcliffe's sojourn, describing it as "semi-routine", while the Kremlin said the CIA chief didn't meet with Vladimir Putin. But there was nothing normal about the visit, unless secret flights to Moscow have been missed by the media. The last known trip by a CIA director to Moscow was in 2021 when it was feared that Putin would attack Ukraine. Spoiler: he did.

Culture **Society, identity and belonging**

Infinity forever

Yayoi Kusama, princess of polka dots, has died aged 97. Kusama's phallic sculptures and psychedelic installations were initially dismissed by the male-dominated art industry. But she later won international acclaim and became known for her mirror-panelled *Infinity Rooms*, which continue to draw crowds of selfie-takers to museums across the world. Kusama was Japan's highest valued contemporary artist, with one of her paintings fetching \$10.5m in 2022. She struggled with mental illness and spent nearly 50 years voluntarily living in a Tokyo psychiatric hospital, withdrawn from the public gaze even as her stature grew.

Thanks for reading. Please tell your friends to [sign up](#) and [tell us](#) what you think. We'll be taking a break for the bank holiday. See you on Tuesday.

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Additional reporting by Xavier Greenwood, Louise Tickle and Evan Moffitt. Edited by Xavier Greenwood.

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